

# AI VISIBILITY CHECKLIST

A practical client-facing checklist for improving how AI systems find, understand, and verify your business

## What this checklist is for

AI tools do not work exactly like traditional search engines. Search engines return a list of pages. AI systems generate answers based on what they know, what they can access, and what they can verify. This checklist helps identify whether your business is structured in a way that gives AI systems a fair chance to understand and trust it.

## Plain-English analogy

Traditional search is like using a library card catalog: you search a topic, get a list of matching books, and can see which books were returned. AI is more like asking a librarian: the librarian gives you a custom answer based on what they know, what they can access, and how they interpret your question. They may mention sources, but you do not see every source considered or how each source was weighed.

**Reality check:** This checklist does not guarantee that ChatGPT, Gemini, Claude, Perplexity, Copilot, or any other AI system will recommend your business. It identifies practical gaps that may make your business harder to discover, understand, verify, or confidently recommend.

## How to Use This Checklist

For each item, mark one of the following:

| Yes                   | Partial                      | No              | Unsure       |
|-----------------------|------------------------------|-----------------|--------------|
| Already in good shape | Exists but needs improvement | Missing or weak | Needs review |

Prioritize fixes where the answer is No, Partial, or Unsure and the page/topic has commercial value. Low-volume or low-intent topics may not justify heavy effort.

## 1. Can AI Systems Find the Business?

**Why it matters:** If important pages are hard to crawl, buried, blocked, or missing from discovery files, AI systems and search systems may never reach the information they need.

☐ Important pages are indexable and return clean 200 status codes.

☐ The XML sitemap includes the most important service, product, location, and resource pages.

☐ The robots.txt file does not accidentally block important pages or critical crawlers.

☐ Important content is not hidden behind forms, login walls, scripts, or interactions that crawlers may not process well.

- ☐ The site has clear internal links to priority service, product, location, and resource pages.
- ☐ The site has a human-visible Website Guide, Service Guide, Resource Index, or similar page that explains the site structure in plain language.
- ☐ The site has an RSS/Atom feed for recent or meaningfully updated content, such as guides, resources, FAQs, case studies, or announcements.
- ☐ A plain-text AI content guide, such as /llms.txt, exists or has been considered for key pages and citation guidance.

## 2. Can AI Systems Understand What the Business Does?

**Why it matters:** AI systems need clear, extractable facts. Vague marketing copy makes it harder to identify what the business offers, where it operates, and who it serves.

- ☐ Each key page clearly states the business name, service/product category, and location or service area.
- ☐ Important pages include a concise summary near the top that explains what the business does.
- ☐ Service, product, and location pages use specific headings instead of vague promotional headings.
- ☐ The site clearly explains eligibility, pricing, financing, delivery, availability, service areas, or other decision factors where relevant.
- ☐ FAQ sections answer real customer questions in direct, factual language.
- ☐ Content avoids generic filler that sounds good but communicates little useful information.
- ☐ Multi-location or multi-service businesses clearly connect which services are available in which locations.
- ☐ The same business name, service terminology, and location information are used consistently across the site.

## 3. Can AI Systems Verify and Trust the Business?

**Why it matters:** AI systems are more likely to trust information when it is supported by consistent third-party sources, reviews, listings, and clear entity signals.

- ☐ Google Business Profile information is complete, current, and consistent with the website.
- ☐ Bing Places and Apple Business Connect information are accurate where applicable.
- ☐ Core directory listings use consistent name, address, phone, website, categories, and hours.
- ☐ Review volume and quality are competitive for the market.
- ☐ The business has credible third-party mentions, local citations, industry listings, or partner/vendor references.
- ☐ Important external profiles are linked or referenced where useful and appropriate.

☐ The website includes trust signals such as company history, service policies, guarantees, staff, store photos, or proof points.

☐ The business has a process for improving review acquisition and review response quality.

## 4. Can AI Systems Recommend the Business Over Alternatives?

**Why it matters:** Being found and understood is not enough. AI systems also need enough evidence to explain why this business is a good fit for a specific user need.

☐ The site explains what makes the business different from competitors.

☐ Priority pages include proof points such as reviews, years in business, delivery options, product range, approvals, guarantees, or local expertise.

☐ The site answers high-intent comparison questions users are likely to ask AI tools.

☐ The site includes content for use cases, alternatives, common objections, and decision support.

☐ Location pages include specific local relevance instead of duplicated boilerplate copy.

☐ The business has pages or sections that match commercially valuable customer questions.

☐ Competitor advantages shown in AI answers have been reviewed and compared against the client site.

☐ The business has a clear conversion path from informational pages to calls, forms, directions, or purchases.

## 5. Can AI-Influenced Activity Be Measured?

**Why it matters:** AI visibility cannot be measured perfectly, but useful signals can still be tracked when they are separated honestly.

☐ GA4 is configured to identify known AI referrers where possible.

☐ GA4 reporting includes landing page plus query string, page referrer, and source/medium views.

☐ Known AI tracking parameters, such as utm\_source=chatgpt.com, are included in reporting where relevant.

☐ Server, CDN, Cloudflare, or WAF logs are available or can be requested.

☐ Known AI crawler or fetch agents can be identified in server/CDN logs where available.

☐ A baseline prompt set exists for commercially valuable questions.

☐ AI answer checks record the platform, prompt, date, location context, mentioned brands, and cited sources.

☐ Direct traffic increases to important pages are reviewed as probable signals only, not proof of AI traffic.

## Priority Worksheet

Use this section to identify which issues are worth fixing first. The goal is not to fix every possible item. The goal is to prioritize work that has commercial value.

| Gap or issue | Affected page/source | Business value | Effort | Priority |
|--------------|----------------------|----------------|--------|----------|
|              |                      |                |        |          |
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## Signal Types to Track

| Signal Type                         | What It Means                                                                            | How to Treat It                                    |
|-------------------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|----------------------------------------------------|
| Confirmed AI referral traffic       | A user visit with an identifiable AI referrer or tracking parameter.                     | Useful, but likely undercounts total AI influence. |
| Confirmed AI crawler/fetch activity | An AI crawler or user-triggered AI fetch appears in server/CDN logs.                     | Shows access, not recommendation or user exposure. |
| AI answer visibility                | The business appears in a tested AI answer or citation result.                           | Directional, because prompts and outputs vary.     |
| Probable AI-influenced traffic      | Direct or unassigned traffic to target pages that correlates with AI visibility signals. | Treat as inference, not proof.                     |

## What to Do Next

If several items are marked Partial, No, or Unsure, the next step is not guessing. The next step is an AI visibility audit that identifies where the business may be difficult for AI systems to find, understand, verify, or recommend.

### A proper audit should review:

- technical discovery and crawl access
- content clarity and entity structure
- structured data and machine-readable facts
- Website Guide, RSS/Atom feed, XML sitemap, and /llms.txt coverage
- third-party citations, reviews, and trust signals
- AI answer samples and competitor visibility
- GA4, server/CDN logs, and baseline monitoring setup

**Simple rule:** Do not chase vague AI visibility. Fix the practical issues that make your business harder to discover, understand, verify, and choose.